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Section Title(S): Kinship And Marriage

There is no ceremony marking the commencement of married life; the couple simply build themselves a shelter or hut adjacent to that of the girl's parents. They address one another as *kxaoma* (man, i.e., husband) and *g//eisa* (woman, i.e., wife) and adopt the appropriate affinal terminology in respect to one another's kin. According to my informants, a boy would treat his *babama* (MB, FZH) and his *ma:sa* (fz, mbw) as avoidance kin as soon as he began to court their daughter, anticipating their conversion from joking kin to avoidance affines by the fact of his marrying their daughter.

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A girl's menarchial ceremony (see Silberbauer, 1963) marks her transition from childhood to womanhood and illustrates a number of G/wi values and attitudes. Parent-child bonds are emphasized by the mother's role in guarding and attending her daughter during the latter's seclusion prior to the ceremony. The mother also shepherds her daughter through the early stages of the ceremony. That a husband is considered to be weakened and abnormally vulnerable to danger when his wife menstruates indicates the strength of the bond between them. He will not hunt, nor even touch his weapons, lest an accident befall him. When a girl goes into menarchial seclusion, her husband leaves the conjugal shelter or hut and retires to the bachelor's shelter, where he is cared for by the men of the band until his wife's menstrual flow has ceased and the menarchial ceremonies commence. He joins his wife for the last and longest phase of the ceremonies. The couple are tonsured and their bodies are tattooed in matching patterns of lines and inoculated with the blood of one another's wounds. Magical herbal preparations are mixed with this blood to ensure a harmonious married life and to ward off want and disaster from the couple. While seated together, husband and wife are

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individually admonished to observe the conjugal virtues of patience, discretion, loyalty, and affection. There is no mention of fertility and the focus of this part of the ceremony is on the relationships between husband and wife and with other band members. It is clear from this affirmation of marriage, following the rite of passage into womanhood, that a marriage, although intended to be lasting, is likely to be threatened by social as well as environmental forces. It is also apparent that chastity in either partner is a matter of demeanor and discretion rather than of actual sexual behavior. The repeated reference to the couple's mutual dependence emphasizes the complementarity of their roles and denies any view of institutionalized dominance of either partner.

When the tattooing is completed, the girl's mother takes her by the  152 hand and gently leads her out of the seclusion hut. She holds to her daughter's forehead one after another of the food plants available at the time, pronounces the name of the plant and tells her daughter its uses and virtues. Then, stretching her arm out and pointing around the horizon, she introduces the band territory to her daughter. "This is the country of all of us, and of you; you will always find food here" (which also has the connotation of "you will always be at home here"). The girls and young women in attendance then run the girl through a symbolic shower of rain, which, apart from being intended to ensure that she does not suffer drought in her life, associates her with the life-force of rain. This is not symbolic of fertility as such but of a wider view of life, which includes survival. Informants explained that the association would make the girl beloved of people among whom she would live.

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